Week 4: Negotiation, Culture and Organisational Communication

NPTEL Soft Skills · Prof. Binod Mishra · Lectures 16–20

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Lecture 16: Negotiation Skills I

Week 4 · Course book PDF pages 240–254 (printed pages 239–253)

Learning objectives

- Define negotiation and list its ingredients.
- Differentiate formal and informal negotiation.
- Explain factors affecting negotiation: place, time, atmosphere, subjective factors, fear, influence.
- State the qualities of a negotiator and the stages of negotiation; define BATNA, WATNA and ZOPA.

Important definitions

NEGOTIATION (ALAN FOWLER)

A form of meeting or discussion in which the parties use argument and persuasion to reach an agreed decision or action. (The transcript spells the name ‘Alan Flower’.)

NEGOTIATION (PROCESS VIEW)

A process of combining conflicting positions into a common position, turning conflict into agreement.

BATNA

Best Alternative To a Negotiated Agreement: your fallback if the negotiation fails.

WATNA

Worst Alternative To a Negotiated Agreement: the worst result that you must avoid accepting out of fear or influence.

ZOPA

Zone Of Possible Agreement: the range in which the parties' interests overlap and agreement is possible.

WIN-WIN SITUATION

An agreement that benefits both parties.

Core concepts

Nature of negotiation

- Arises when there is a **conflict or deadlock** or difference of opinion.
- Needs **two parties** with interests; discussion must not be one-sided.
- Works through **persuasion and instruction, not authority**.
- Outcome should benefit both parties; sometimes lose-win, ideally win-win.
- Examples: buying a car; employee seeking a raise from the boss.

Formal versus informal negotiation

- **Formal:** pre-announced date, venue, time and agenda; parties know the subject; usually **three people**: two parties and a negotiator/observer.
- **Informal:** not announced; casual, friendly; two persons; little preparation; position and familiarity can create pressure or deadlock; need extra restraint.

Factors affecting negotiation

- **Place:** own place gives comfort, confidence and access to documents.
- **Time:** mutually suitable; not imposed.
- **Atmosphere:** free exchange; no threat; seek common ground.
- **Subjective factors:** personal relationships, bias of observer, **fear**, influence and mutual obligation, personal ambition.
- Past negotiations may help.
- **Kennedy:** "Let us never negotiate out of fear, but let us never fear to negotiate."

Qualities of a negotiator

- **Confidence** from preparation; have a plan B.
- **Appearance** – dress with dignity.
- **Outlook** – flexible, ready to concede but never agree unless you have gained.
- **Honesty and reliability** – know your subject and both sides' strengths and weaknesses.
- **Competence** – communication and reading meta-communication and facial reactions.
- Flexibility and positivity; no agreement can be totally fair.

Stages and tactics

- **Preparation** (study the issue, gather facts, know upper and lower limits) → **Negotiation/interaction** (simple language, stay cool, conducive atmosphere) → agreement.

- Use polite language: “I think we need some more clarity in this regard”; “Can you repeat what you said earlier?”
- Facts must be factual and consistent; many negotiations fail because of poor control of vocabulary.
- **Upper limit** = how much you concede; **lower limit** = loss you can accept.
- Prepare BATNA; avoid WATNA; aim for ZOPA and a win-win outcome.

Types, classifications and characteristics

Formal versus informal negotiation

Point	Formal	Informal
Announcement	Date, venue, time and agenda announced	Not announced
Preparation	Prepared in advance	Little or no time
Persons	Two parties plus negotiator/observer	Two persons
Atmosphere	Official	Friendly, may be influenced by position

Key acronyms

Acronym	Expansion
BATNA	Best Alternative To a Negotiated Agreement
WATNA	Worst Alternative To a Negotiated Agreement
ZOPA	Zone Of Possible Agreement

Theories, principles, models and contributors

DEFINITION OF NEGOTIATION — ALAN FOWLER (‘FLOWER’ IN TRANSCRIPT)

A meeting or discussion where argument and persuasion lead to an agreed decision.

FEAR AND NEGOTIATION — JOHN F. KENNEDY

“Let us never negotiate out of fear, but let us never fear to negotiate.”

Examples and applications

EXAMPLE

Haggling over the price of a car; the seller must also benefit.

EXAMPLE

An employee negotiating a raise with the boss.

EXAMPLE

Students negotiating marks with a faculty member (fear factor).

EXAMPLE

Using ‘Can you repeat what you said earlier?’ to buy time.

Comparison tables

BATNA versus WATNA

BATNA	WATNA
Best fallback if talks fail	Worst outcome to avoid
Gives confidence and strength	Accepted only under fear or influence
Prepare in advance	Never accept

Important facts for MCQ revision

EXAM TIP

- Negotiation arises from conflict and needs two parties.
- Formal negotiation announces date, venue, time and agenda; three persons involved.
- Informal negotiation is not pre-announced.
- Negotiation works by persuasion, not authority.
- BATNA, WATNA, ZOPA acronyms.
- Qualities: confidence, appearance, outlook, honesty, competence, flexibility.
- Kennedy’s fear quotation.
- Facts must be consistent; know upper and lower limits.
- Ideal outcome is win-win.

QUIZ-RELATED CONCEPTS (QUIZ PDF PAGE REFERENCES)

Question	Quiz PDF page	Concept tested	Type
W4 Q1	p.15	BATNA, WATNA and negotiation terms	MCQ
W4 Q2	p.15	Negotiation: quotations	MCQ
W4 Q3	p.15	Definition of negotiation	MCQ
W4 Q4	p.15	Nature of negotiation	MCQ
W4 Q9	p.16	ZOPA	Fill-in-the-blank
W4 Q10	p.16	Qualities of a negotiator	MSQ
W4 Q11	p.17	Formal negotiation	MSQ
W4 Q12	p.17	Subjective factors in negotiation	MSQ

Full question text and answers: Quiz analysis.

Summary

Negotiation turns conflict into agreement through argument and persuasion. Formal negotiations are pre-announced with an agenda; informal ones are casual. Place, time, atmosphere, personal relations and fear affect results. A negotiator needs confidence, dignity, flexibility, honesty and competence, must prepare facts and limits, secure a BATNA, avoid WATNA and seek a ZOPA that yields a win-win outcome.

Practice questions

Q1 (MCQ) ZOPA stands for:

A. Zone Of Possible Agreement
B. Zero Option Plan Agreement
C. Zone Of Prior Action
D. Zone Of Peaceful Argument

> **Answer:** A
> **Why:** It is the range of possible agreement.

Q2 (MCQ) WATNA is:

A. Best alternative
B. Worst alternative to a negotiated agreement
C. A kind of authority
D. A meeting type

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** It must be avoided.

Q3 (MSQ) Which are true for formal negotiation?

A. Agenda announced

B. Venue announced

C. Always unplanned

D. Often involves an observer

> **Answer:** A, B, D
> **Why:** Informal is unplanned.

Q4 (T/F) Negotiation should be conducted through authority rather than persuasion.

> **Answer:** False
> **Why:** It works through persuasion.

Q5 (Fill) BATNA stands for Best _____ To a Negotiated Agreement.

> **Answer:** Alternative
> **Why:** It is the fallback option.

Q6 (Short) State three qualities of a good negotiator.

> **Answer:** Confidence, honesty and flexibility (also appearance, outlook, competence).
> **Why:** Preparation builds confidence.

Revision checklist

☐ I can define negotiation.

☐ I can compare formal and informal negotiation.

☐ I can list factors and qualities.

☐ I can expand BATNA, WATNA, ZOPA.

☐ I remember Kennedy's fear quote.

Lecture 17: Negotiation Skills II

Week 4 · Course book PDF pages 255–269 (printed pages 254–268)

Learning objectives

- Explain persuasion factors in negotiation: style, you-attitude, body language, summarising.
- Describe the three phases: preparation, interaction (negotiation), implementation.
- Distinguish red, blue and purple negotiation styles.
- List negotiation approaches (collaborate, accommodate, compromise, control, avoid) and dos and don’ts.

Important definitions

YOU-ATTITUDE

Convincing the other party that they will benefit; telling them the ‘sunny side’ of the deal and letting them talk while you listen.

SUNNY SIDE OF THE DEAL

The advantages to the other party that you highlight to persuade them.

RED STYLE

Self-centred, competitive negotiation style.

BLUE STYLE

Cooperative, less competitive style.

PURPLE STYLE

A mix of red and blue; the recommended style.

WIN-WIN / WIN-LOSE / LOSE-WIN

Possible outcomes of a negotiation; no negotiation gives a total win to one party.

Core concepts

Persuasion factors

- **Style:** language, convincing approach, presenting strengths and weaknesses; each party presents its case first.
- **You-attitude:** highlight the benefit to the other; combine talking and listening.
- **Body language:** glances, eyes and face complement words.

- **Summarising:** "I have said this, you have said this... something still needs discussion."

Agreement is the culmination ("sum and substance") of exchanged views.

Three phases of negotiation

1. **Preparation** – plan, study pros and cons, know your strength and the other's weakness, upper and lower limits, anticipate (plan B), discover the real issue, be realistic. **Tim Hindle:** it is almost impossible for a negotiator to do too much preparation.
2. **Interaction / negotiation** – introductions (often by the observer), exchange initial views, test the initial position, look for common ground (ZOPA), small sacrifices, watch time, note down the points of agreement, control vocabulary.
3. **Implementation** – decide roles after agreement and ensure the agreement sustains.

Negotiation styles by colour

- **Red:** self-centred, competitive.
- **Blue:** cooperative.
- **Purple:** blend; best choice.

Approaches / qualities

- **Collaborate** – avoid confrontation.
- **Accommodate** – polite, allow more room, especially with other cultures.
- **Compromise** – do not remain rigid.
- **Control** – be forgiving, conceding, convincing; ask for clarification advantageously.
- **Avoid** – keep emotion out of sight, avoid confrontational tone.

Dos and don'ts

- Keep some key points in reserve; do not say everything at once.
- Do not get personal; read the tone, not only the words.
- Do not prolong discussion after agreement; sign at the right time and record points.
- Acknowledge the other party's cooperation.
- Be ready for deadlock, defeat and lose-win outcomes; hide signs of loss and stay optimistic.
- Allow other cultures more time and space.
- "In business you do not get what you deserve, you get what you negotiate."
- Negotiation is cooperation, not competition.

Types, classifications and characteristics

Three phases of negotiation

Phase	Key tasks
Preparation	Study issue, strengths/weaknesses, limits, plan B
Interaction	Exchange views, test positions, find common ground, agree, note points
Implementation	Assign roles, carry out the agreement

Negotiation styles

Style	Nature
Red	Competitive, self-centred
Blue	Cooperative
Purple	Blend of red and blue (preferred)

Theories, principles, models and contributors

PREPARATION — TIM HINDLE (‘HANDLE’ IN TRANSCRIPT)

It is almost impossible for a negotiator to do too much preparation.

Examples and applications

EXAMPLE

A schoolboy negotiates a bike with parents: bike for a 9-point CGPA.

EXAMPLE

Companies selling skill-based labs show the sunny side.

EXAMPLE

Cross-cultural delay: patient negotiators can win more concessions.

Comparison tables

Red, blue and purple styles

Style	Orientation	Result
Red	Self-centred	Deadlock risk
Blue	Cooperative	Smooth but may concede too much
Purple	Mixed	Balanced and recommended

Important facts for MCQ revision

EXAM TIP

- Three phases: preparation, interaction, implementation.
- Red = competitive; blue = cooperative; purple = mix.
- You-attitude means telling the sunny side.
- Tim Hindle: almost impossible to over-prepare.
- Agree and write down the points; decide roles.
- No negotiation gives a total win to only one party.
- Get what you negotiate, not what you deserve.
- Be patient with cultures that delay; allow concessions.

QUIZ-RELATED CONCEPTS (QUIZ PDF PAGE REFERENCES)

Question	Quiz PDF page	Concept tested	Type
W4 Q7	p.16	Colour-based negotiation styles	MCQ
W4 Q9	p.16	ZOPA	Fill-in-the-blank

Full question text and answers: Quiz analysis.

Summary

Negotiation strategy depends on persuasion: style, you-attitude, body language and summarising. It runs through preparation, interaction and implementation. The purple style, blending cooperation and competition, is preferred, supported by collaboration, accommodation, compromise, control and emotional avoidance. Negotiators keep some points in reserve, record agreements, acknowledge cooperation and accept that outcomes can be win-win, win-lose or lose-win.

Practice questions

Q1 MCQ The recommended negotiation style is:

A. Red

B. Blue

C. Purple

D. Green

> **Answer:** C
> **Why:** It mixes cooperation and competition.

Q2 (MCQ) ‘You-attitude’ means:

A. Talking only about yourself

B. Showing the other party their benefit

C. Remaining silent

D. Using authority

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** Tell them the sunny side.

Q3 (MSQ) Which are phases of negotiation?

A. Preparation

B. Interaction

C. Implementation

D. Elimination

> **Answer:** A, B, C
> **Why:** Elimination is not a phase.

Q4 (T/F) A negotiator should reveal all key points at the start.

> **Answer:** False
> **Why:** Keep some in reserve for concessions.

Q5 (Fill) A style that is self-centred and competitive is the _____ style.

> **Answer:** red
> **Why:** Blue is cooperative.

Q6 (Short) Why should points of agreement be written down?

> **Answer:** So that the agreement is clear and sustains in implementation.
> **Why:** Vocabulary affects meaning.

Revision checklist

☐ I know the three phases.

☐ I can contrast red, blue and purple.

☐ I can list approaches and dos and don’ts.

☐ I understand you-attitude.

☐ I remember outcome types.

Lecture 18: Culture as Communication

Week 4 · Course book PDF pages 270–288 (printed pages 269–287)

Learning objectives

- Define culture and explain how it affects communication.
- Explain cultural shock, diaspora and globalisation (GATT, NAFTA).
- List the dimensions of culture: context, individualism, formality, communication style, time orientation.
- Compare communication styles of Americans, Japanese, Arabs, Mexicans, Germans, Europeans and others, and cite translation blunders.

Important definitions

CULTURE

A combination of traits, behaviours, values, myths and traditions of a group; the totality of a group's thoughts, experiences and patterns of behaviour and their contact with other cultures. It is learnt and dynamic.

CULTURAL SHOCK

The feeling of isolation or being a loner that arises when one is unfamiliar with a different culture's way of living and responding.

GLOBAL VILLAGE

The world seen as interconnected through technology, trade and travel.

DIASPORA

People of one country settled in another country.

CULTURAL SENSITIVITY

Awareness and respect for differences between cultures when communicating.

DEFERENCE VS DIFFERENCE

The lecture advises showing deference (respect) rather than difference.

Core concepts

Why culture matters

- We assume the world behaves as we do; exposure to other cultures shows differences.

- Culture shapes eating, dress, vocabulary, festivals, thinking and identity; it gives a sense of belonging.
- Globalisation: GATT (General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade) and NAFTA (North American Free Trade Agreement), IT and transport exchange cultures; workplaces are multicultural. Example: idli–dosa in the north.
- Cultures are logical (a cat crossing the road is an omen to Indians) and dynamic; learn symbols, rituals, values, heroes and worships.
- Components to understand: language, gestures, appearance, religion, philosophy, values, family customs, communication systems.
- Example of cultural shock: the film/novel *The Namesake* (childbirth abroad alone).
- Gandhi: different ways to reach God, but the aim is one.

Major dimensions of culture

1. **Context** (high versus low)
2. **Individualism**
3. **Formality**
4. **Communication style**
5. **Time orientation**

Formality and style

- **Americans:** casual, direct, first names or titles, uncomfortable with silence and delay, take words literally; 'hamburger style' criticism (praise bun, criticism meat, praise bun).
- **Europeans:** formal; do not use first names without invitation.
- **Japan/China:** use titles; Japanese treat card exchange and signing as ritual.
- **Mexicans:** value courtesies and food before business; hurt if pushed to business.
- **Arabs, South Americans and Asians:** friendship first; poetic and indirect language.
- **Germans:** direct but understated; **Nigerians:** quiet and clear; **Japanese:** subtle.
- Asians use silence to gain concessions.

Contracts and context

- **Americans** (low context): contracts are specific and word-based.
- **Greeks:** a formal statement.
- **Japanese:** a statement of intention that can improve.
- **Mexicans:** an artistic exercise achievable in an ideal world.
- **Arabs** (high context): contract is insulting; stress non-verbal cues.

Space and time

- US and Canada keep about five feet; this is too close or too far for others.
- Boss in the corner (US) versus middle (Mexico).
- North Americans treat time as a commodity; Asians deliberate long; some cultures are relaxed (an American waited two hours for a purchase).

Translation blunders

- Swiss restaurant: "Our wines will make you forget everything / leave you nowhere."

- “Women are not allowed to have their children at the bar.”
- “Our water has been passed by the manager himself.”

Understand the essence, not the literal words.

Types, classifications and characteristics

Dimensions of culture

Dimension	Contrast
Context	High versus low
Individualism	Individual versus group
Formality	Tradition, titles, rituals
Communication style	Direct versus indirect
Time orientation	Time as commodity versus flexible

Theories, principles, models and contributors

HAMBURGER STYLE OF MANAGEMENT — OBSERVATION ON AMERICANS

Open with warm talk, deliver criticism in the middle, close with reassurance (the buns).

Examples and applications

EXAMPLE

Breakfast in Kuala Lumpur and dinner in Delhi.

EXAMPLE

Brother returns from abroad with changed behaviour.

EXAMPLE

Cat crossing the road as an omen in India.

EXAMPLE

The Namesake and cultural shock.

EXAMPLE

Hotel advertisement translation blunders.

Comparison tables

Communication styles by culture

Culture	Style
American	Direct, literal, casual, impatient with silence
German	Direct but understated, formal
Japanese	Subtle, ritual cards, statement of intention
Arab/South American	Poetic, friendship first, high context
Mexican	Courtesy first; contract is artistic ideal
Nigerian	Quiet, clear

Important facts for MCQ revision

EXAM TIP

- Culture is learnt and dynamic.
- GATT and NAFTA promote trade across cultures.
- Dimensions: context, individualism, formality, communication style, time orientation.
- Americans: hamburger style; low context; time is money.
- Mexicans prefer courtesies before business.
- Arabs consider contracts insulting (high context).
- US/Canada keep about five feet of space.
- Cultural shock causes isolation (The Namesake).
- Europeans do not use first names without invitation.

Summary

Culture is the learnt set of traits, values and behaviours of a group and strongly shapes communication. Globalisation brings cultural contact and, sometimes, cultural shock. Cultures differ in context, individualism, formality, communication style and time orientation; low-context Americans and Germans are direct and word-based, while high-context Arabs, Japanese and Asians stress relationship, silence and non-verbal cues. Respect, deference and learning are the keys to cross-cultural success.

Practice questions

Q1 (MCQ) Which is a dimension of culture mentioned?

A. Climate

B. Time orientation

C. Latitude

D. Currency

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** Context, individualism, formality, style, time orientation.

Q2 (MCQ) The ‘hamburger style’ is associated with:

A. Japanese

B. Americans

C. Arabs

D. Mexicans

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** Praise, criticism, praise.

Q3 (MSQ) Select high-context cultures from the lecture’s discussion.

A. Arab

B. Japanese

C. American

D. German

> **Answer:** A, B
> **Why:** Americans and Germans rely on words.

Q4 (T/F) GATT and NAFTA are trade agreements.

> **Answer:** True
> **Why:** They helped goods and cultures move.

Q5 (Fill) Feeling isolated in an unfamiliar culture is called cultural _____.

> **Answer:** shock
> **Why:** As in The Namesake.

Q6 (Short) Why should translations of advertisements be checked?

> **Answer:** Literal translation can produce absurd meanings, e.g. ‘our wines will leave you nowhere’.
> **Why:** Convey the essence.

Revision checklist

☐ I can define culture.
☐ I know the five dimensions.
☐ I can contrast American, Japanese, Arab and Mexican styles.
☐ I can explain cultural shock.
☐ I remember translation blunders.

Lecture 19: Communicating across Cultures

Week 4 · Course book PDF pages 289–304 (printed pages 288–303)

Learning objectives

- Define communicating across cultures and Alfred G. Smith's definition of culture.
- Contrast low-context and high-context cultures.
- Distinguish intercultural, cross-cultural and global communication contexts.
- Explain ethnocentrism, stereotyping and the movement toward ethno-relativism; recall cultural examples.

Important definitions

CULTURE (ALFRED G. SMITH)

"Culture is a code we learn and share, and learning and sharing require communication." Communication requires coding and symbols that must be learned and shared. (From *Communication and Culture*.)

INTERCULTURAL COMMUNICATION

Face-to-face interaction among people of diverse cultures (also between subcultures of one country).

GLOBAL CONTEXT

Trans-border transfer of information by institutions and groups.

CROSS-CULTURAL COMMUNICATION

Comparing a phenomenon across cultures; problems arise when meanings differ.

ETHNOCENTRISM

The belief that one's own culture is the best.

ETHNO-RELATIVISM

Accepting that cultures differ and adapting to them; reached through stages from denial to acceptance and adaptation.

STEREOTYPING

An oversimplified view of a culture or community, judging individuals by their group.

Core concepts

Low versus high context

- **Low context** (North America, Scandinavia, France, Germany): logic, written contracts, words, analytical and action-oriented language, individualism, little role for silence and non-words.
- **High context** (Japan, China, Arab countries): meaning from context, intuition, silence and non-verbal cues; contemplative; social harmony and saving face; prefer friendship to contract.
- Example: a Japanese buyer paused, folded arms and closed eyes while the American seller grew impatient.

Communication contexts

- **International:** face-to-face among diverse cultures.
- **Global:** information across borders.
- **Cross-cultural:** comparing across cultures.
- **Intercultural:** interaction between people of different cultures, including subcultures (Indian Bengali versus Bangladeshi Bengali; American versus Indian English).

Cultural variations

- **Superstition:** a worm in pulque is fortunate in Mexico; the Japanese *Maneki neko* (beckoning cat) attracts customers.
- **Numbers:** 8 is lucky in China and Hong Kong; 4 sounds like death (shi) so no room 4 in hospitals.
- **Space:** Arabs of the same sex stand closer; North Americans keep five feet.
- **Silence:** Americans cannot bear long silence.
- **Colour, greeting and touch** differ.
- **Saying no:** USA/Canada shake head; Bulgaria nods up and down; Japan moves the right hand; Sicily raises the chin.
- An Indian politely refusing food saying ‘no’ went hungry among Americans.
- HP: French engineers wrote shorter e-mails, which Americans read as withholding information.
- Mazda: casual baseball caps hurt Americans’ feelings.
- Gifts: a clock in China invites evil; do not gift an Arab’s wife; a rose to a German lady may signal romance. ‘How was your weekend?’ may seem intrusive.
- Gestures: Thatcher’s victory sign and the thumbs-up may be negative elsewhere; Asian men holding hands is friendly.

Variables to watch

Ethnocentrism, education, religious faith, country laws, language and use of space are variables in cross-cultural communication.

Bridging cultural gaps

- Tolerance, empathy, patience; do not judge; give others space and time.
- Avoid stereotypes (a basket of mangoes: not all are rotten).
- Move from ethnocentrism to ethno-relativism through **six stages** (denial, defence, minimisation, acceptance, adaptation, integration), seeking commonalities.
- Indians care about image; Mexicans and Asians about harmony and saving face.

- *Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam* (“Ayam nijah paro veti…”): the world is one family.

Types, classifications and characteristics

Low versus high context cultures

Feature	Low context	High context
Countries	North America, Scandinavia, France, Germany	Japan, China, Arab countries
Meaning in	Words	Context, silence, non-verbal cues
Contracts	Written and specific	Relationship, trust
Orientation	Individualism, action	Harmony, contemplation

Ways to say ‘no’

Place	Gesture
USA/Canada	Shake head side to side
Bulgaria	Nod up and down
Japan	Move right hand
Sicily	Raise chin

Theories, principles, models and contributors

CULTURE AS A CODE — ALFRED G. SMITH

Culture is a code we learn and share; sharing requires communication. (The Lecture 2 note records the transcript’s ‘Adam Smith’ attribution as a discrepancy.)

ETHNOCENTRISM TO ETHNO-RELATIVISM — CROSS-CULTURAL MODEL (SIX STAGES)

Denial → defence → minimisation → acceptance → adaptation → integration.

Examples and applications

EXAMPLE

Japanese buyer’s silence versus an American seller’s impatience.

EXAMPLE

Worm in the drink: lucky in Mexico, unlucky elsewhere.

EXAMPLE

Indian politely says ‘no’ to second helpings and is not offered more.

EXAMPLE

HP’s French and US engineers; Mazda baseball caps.

Comparison tables

Ethnocentrism versus ethno-relativism

Ethnocentrism	Ethno-relativism
My culture is the best	Cultures are different but equal
Denial and defence	Acceptance and adaptation
Judges by own standards	Understands others’ viewpoint

Important facts for MCQ revision

EXAM TIP

- Low context: North America, Scandinavia, France, Germany.
- High context: Japan, China, Arab countries.
- Number 8 is lucky; 4 sounds like death in Hong Kong/China.
- Maneki neko is the Japanese beckoning cat.
- North Americans keep about 5 feet of space.
- Sicily raises the chin to say no; Bulgaria nods for no.
- A clock as a gift is bad in China.
- Ethno-relativism has six stages.
- Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam shows the Asian ideal.

QUIZ-RELATED CONCEPTS (QUIZ PDF PAGE REFERENCES)

Question	Quiz PDF page	Concept tested	Type
W4 Q5	p.15	Culture and numbers	MCQ
W4 Q6	p.16	Definition of culture	MCQ
W4 Q13	p.17	Low-context cultures	MSQ
W4 Q15	p.17	Cultural differences in gestures and style	Match the columns

Full question text and answers: Quiz analysis.

Summary

Communication across cultures requires understanding that culture is a shared code. Low-context cultures trust words and contracts, while high-context cultures read silence, context and relationships. Differences in gestures, numbers, gifts, space, colour and ways of saying no cause misunderstanding.

Avoid ethnocentrism and stereotypes; practise tolerance, empathy and adaptation, moving towards ethno-relativism.

Practice questions

Q1 (MCQ) Which culture is low context?

A. Japan

B. China

C. Germany

D. Arab countries

> **Answer:** C
> **Why:** North America, Scandinavia, France and Germany are low context.

Q2 (MCQ) The belief that one's own culture is best is:

A. Ethno-relativism

B. Ethnocentrism

C. Stereotype

D. Diaspora

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** It must be avoided.

Q3 (MSQ) Which are correctly matched ways of saying no?

A. Bulgaria – nod up and down

B. Sicily – raise chin

C. USA – nod up and down

D. Japan – move right hand

> **Answer:** A, B, D
> **Why:** In the USA people shake the head.

Q4 (T/F) In Hong Kong the number 4 is lucky.

> **Answer:** False
> **Why:** It resembles the word for death; 8 is lucky.

Q5 (Fill) A Japanese cat figure that attracts customers is _____.

> **Answer:** Maneki neko
> **Why:** The beckoning cat.

Q6 Short How can cultural gaps be bridged?

> **Answer:** By tolerance, empathy, patience, avoiding judgments and stereotypes, and adapting to others' norms.
> **Why:** Move to ethno-relativism.

Revision checklist

☐ I can quote Smith's definition.
☐ I can compare low and high context.
☐ I know the ways of saying no.
☐ I can explain ethnocentrism and ethno-relativism.
☐ I remember gift and number examples.

Lecture 20: Organizational Communication

Week 4 · Course book PDF pages 305–321 (printed pages 304–320)

Learning objectives

- Define organisation and organisational communication (William Scott).
- State functions and objectives of organisational communication.
- Explain managerial roles (interpersonal, informational, decisional) and Maslow's hierarchy at work.
- Describe McGregor's management styles, line and staff management, formal and informal channels, and types of workplace communication.

Important definitions

ORGANISATION

A social unit of people structured and managed to meet a need or pursue collective goals.

ORGANISATIONAL COMMUNICATION (WILLIAM SCOTT)

A process involving transmission and accurate replication of ideas, their dissemination, promotion and distribution, ensured by feedback, to elicit actions that accomplish the goals of the organisation.

INFORMATION MANAGEMENT SYSTEM (IMS)

The core system by which information entering an organisation is managed and used.

LINE MANAGEMENT

People responsible for basic company activities such as manufacturing and sales.

STAFF MANAGEMENT

People who support line management with services such as accounting, distribution and personnel.

GRAPEVINE

An informal channel of casual talk, whispers and rumours.

CRISIS COMMUNICATION

Urgent communication among core managers when something goes wrong; combines persuasion with caution.

Core concepts

Why communication matters in an organisation

- Carry out management, allocate jobs, disseminate information and clarify roles.
- The communication environment shows a person's calibre and is an asset.
- Employees come from different backgrounds, ages, genders and faiths; communication must suit everyone.
- Communication flows to bosses, groups and other departments.

Functions of communication

1. **Forecasting** – what we want to do and where we want to be.
2. **Organising** – distributing work and responsibilities among divisions (quality control, HR, accounts, inventory).
3. **Instructing / persuading** – leader instructs, persuades or orders.
4. **Coordinating** – across divisions.
5. **Controlling** – the leader controls and is a role model.

Objectives

- Improve job performance and update knowledge (workshops, conferences).
- Create belonging; make employees feel heard and appreciated.
- Convince employees about decisions; set daily, monthly and annual aims jointly.
- Assign roles and empower employees with information.

Managerial roles

- **Interpersonal** – talking with individuals and groups.
- **Informational** – receiving and giving information; be like an ambassador who knows everything.
- **Decisional** – listen to problems, interpret information and decide.

Maslow's hierarchy at work

Physiological (food, shelter, salary) → safety/security → social (belonging, love, appreciation) → esteem/ego → **self-actualisation** (morality, creativity, spontaneity, purpose). "Ambition is everyone's slave."

McGregor's two styles

- **Traditional (Theory X):** workers need only basic needs; treated as labour; language of control.
- **Modern (Theory Y):** balance of control and freedom; workers treated as humans with higher needs; language of persuasion; manager must understand their needs.

Communication flow and channels

- **Vertical** (downward from top, upward), **horizontal**, **crosswise** (diagonal), and **spiral** for policy announcements (hike, bonus).
- **Line and staff** management coordinate; staff support line.
- **Formal** and **informal** channels (casual chat, grapevine). Managers may use the grapevine for warnings or to caution disgruntled employees; filter its information.

- **Koontz and O'Donnell:** "The most effective communication results when managers utilise the informal organisational channels to supplement the formal organisational channels."

Types of communication at workplace

- **Statutory** – norms, terms and conditions, policies, bulletins.
- **Crisis management** – urgent meetings of core members; persuasion and caution.

A satisfied employee is more productive than a dissatisfied one.

Types, classifications and characteristics

Functions of organisational communication

Function	Meaning
Forecasting	Planning goals and future position
Organising	Distributing tasks and divisions
Instructing / persuading	Directing employees
Coordinating	Linking divisions
Controlling	Monitoring performance; leader as role model

Managerial roles

Role	Description
Interpersonal	Dealing with people
Informational	Receiving and sharing information
Decisional	Interpreting and deciding

Theories, principles, models and contributors

ORGANISATIONAL COMMUNICATION — WILLIAM SCOTT

Transmission and replication of ideas ensured by feedback to accomplish organisational goals.

HIERARCHY OF NEEDS — ABRAHAM MASLOW

Needs move from physiological to self-actualisation.

TRADITIONAL VERSUS MODERN MANAGEMENT — DOUGLAS MCGREGOR

Control-oriented versus freedom and persuasion-oriented styles.

INFORMAL CHANNELS — KOONTZ AND O'DONNELL

Use informal channels to supplement formal ones.

Examples and applications

EXAMPLE

Bank staff gather before opening to hear the day’s plan.

EXAMPLE

Workshops for electricity workers to update knowledge.

EXAMPLE

A manager plants messages on the grapevine to caution disgruntled staff.

Comparison tables

Traditional versus modern management (McGregor)

Point	Traditional	Modern
View of workers	Labour or resources with basic needs	Humans with higher needs
Language	Control	Persuasion
Freedom	Little	Balance of control and freedom

Line versus staff management

Line	Staff
Manufacturing, sales	Accounting, distribution, personnel
Core activities	Support services

Important facts for MCQ revision

EXAM TIP

- Scott’s definition emphasises feedback and action.
- Functions: forecasting, organising, instructing, coordinating, controlling.
- Roles: interpersonal, informational, decisional.
- Maslow’s hierarchy applies to employees.
- McGregor: traditional versus modern.
- Flows: vertical, horizontal, crosswise, spiral.
- Types: statutory and crisis communication.
- IMS means information management system.
- Satisfied employees are more productive.

QUIZ-RELATED CONCEPTS (QUIZ PDF PAGE REFERENCES)

Question	Quiz PDF page	Concept tested	Type
W1 Q8	p.4	Grapevine (informal channel)	MCQ
W4 Q8	p.16	McGregor's management styles	MCQ
W4 Q14	p.17	Maslow's hierarchy of needs	MSQ

Full question text and answers: Quiz analysis.

Summary

Organisational communication carries ideas through formal and informal channels so that goals are achieved. Its functions include forecasting, organising, instructing, coordinating and controlling; managers play interpersonal, informational and decisional roles. Understanding Maslow’s needs and McGregor’s styles helps leaders persuade rather than only control. Statutory and crisis communication, line–staff coordination and a careful use of the grapevine complete the picture.

Practice questions

Q1 MCQ Who defined organisational communication as ensured by feedback to elicit actions?

A. William Scott
B. Maslow
C. McGregor
D. Mehrabian

> **Answer:** A
> **Why:** Scott’s definition.

Q2 MCQ Which management style uses the language of persuasion?

A. Traditional
B. Modern
C. Authoritarian
D. Rigid

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** McGregor’s modern style.

Q3 (MSQ) Select managerial roles.

A. Interpersonal

B. Informational

C. Decisional

D. Combative

> **Answer:** A, B, C
> **Why:** These are the three roles.

Q4 (T/F) Grapevine information must always be rejected.

> **Answer:** False
> **Why:** It can warn managers but needs filtering.

Q5 (Fill) Support services like accounting belong to _____ management.

> **Answer:** staff
> **Why:** Line handles manufacturing and sales.

Q6 (Short) Name two functions of communication in an organisation.

> **Answer:** Forecasting and controlling (also organising, instructing, coordinating).
> **Why:** Leaders also act as role models.

Revision checklist

☐ I can define organisation and Scott’s definition.

☐ I know the functions and roles.

☐ I can link Maslow and McGregor to employees.

☐ I know the flow types and channels.

☐ I can explain statutory and crisis communication.